

Teen emotions

Teens tend to behave more recklessly when surrounded by their peers than when with adults, and can be especially affected by social feedback, praise, and what others think of them. In part, this is because the prefrontal cortex—the part of the brain that regulates emotional balance, risk-taking, and self-awareness—is one of the last areas to develop. It may seem counterintuitive, but this delay has biological benefits. One such benefit is that an inability to recognize risks allows developing teens to step away from the security of their parents and become independent.



△ Seeking thrills

Feelings of excitement are accompanied by the release of feel-good hormones, such as dopamine. This can result in risk-taking and thrill-seeking behavior.

▷ Over-the-top reactions

As the prefrontal cortex develops, some teens may react to minor incidents in ways that seem out of proportion to the situation.



Evolving reactions

Teens are likely to feel emotions more intensely than children or adults because the prefrontal cortex, the “thinking” part of the brain, develops later than the parts of the brain that trigger emotional response. Until the prefrontal cortex catches up, they are less able to identify or control their emotional responses to situations or actions.

The good news is that the prefrontal cortex is able to make room for change, such as developing emotional control—and unlike emotions themselves, which are instinctive, emotional control can be learned, even before the prefrontal cortex has finished developing.

Managing feelings

Sometimes emotions can take over and lead people to behave in ways that they later regret once their “thinking” brain reengages. This can happen more frequently during the teen years.

If possible, remove yourself from the situation (for example, go into a different room).

Concentrate on your breathing and count to ten, very slowly.

Recognize and accept your emotions, then work out how to react to them constructively.

Exercising, listening to music, or even just writing things down can be positive ways to focus your mind.

PARENT TIPS

Helping teens to manage feelings

- When your teen is feeling emotionally overwhelmed, give them space for their emotions to settle before trying to discuss the cause.
- Try to recognize and respond to the emotion they are experiencing.
- Talk about any issues that need to be resolved once they have their emotions back under control.
- Seeking new opportunities helps teens to become independent. You can support your teen by encouraging them to be bold but thoughtful at the same time.